

Two weeks later, my wife's father, a recently retired Polish officer and landowner, was arrested and taken away by the NKVD [the secret police of the Soviet Union]. We never saw him again. He was likely executed at the Katyn massacre, where thousands of other Polish officers were later found to have been killed.

I immediately sent my wife's mother away. We would never see her again, either.

Winter came in earnest with a scarcity of goods and whisperings of mass deportations. In early February 1940, policemen and landowners and many educated people were arrested and deported along with their relatives. Late one night I received a knock on my door. I walked four armed Russian soldiers. One of them was a man I had spoken with several times over the previous months. I greeted them politely in Russian.

I was ordered to get my coat and accompany them.

I was taken to a station and asked many questions. It was a stroke of luck for me that the Russian soldier to whom I had spoken with in the past was present. After conferring with the others, he said, "because you were born in Siberia, speak Russian, and you're an uneducated worker—much like us, we will not detain you further, you may go for now." He then gently grabbed my elbow and said very quietly, "Go back to your family, Marion, get prepared for deportation to Siberia." I ran home.

At dawn the next morning I retrieved the gold and jewelry. I found my largest boots and heaviest jacket. I lined the bottom of my boots carefully with small coins and put leather over the insoles. I slit the heels, carefully hollowed out what I could, and stuffed larger gold coins inside the cavities. Finally, I opened up various parts of my jacket and distributed more gold chain and coins in it—with great care so they did not rattle and were hard to detect.

Just days later, we were awakened before dawn and told we were being deported to Siberia, with 15 minutes to gather any personal belongings needed for immediate use. Our land, homes, and possessions were now property of the Russian state. My wife, my three-year-old daughter, and I were put into a truck with a group of others and taken to a railroad station.

We would never see our parents or siblings again or set foot on Polish soil.

I was only relieved that they did not check my jacket or my shoes. My gold was going with me.

When the train arrived many hours later we were put into cattle cars. The trip to Siberia took almost 3 weeks. It was hellish, we were cramped in overcrowded cars with no toilet, and only a hole cut in the floor, with scarcely any food or water. We were given dark bread and water every few days. Many died, and they were simply thrown off the train, be they men women or children. I recall the last time I wept during those years: a baby had been born in our boxcar during the journey; it had died and was cast off the train by the soldiers like rubbish.